

DPCM Module (Jan 2026)

Assigned 20 minute Presentation Research question:

Overview of Irish Defence Policy: Key Challenges and Strategic Directions. An examination of Irish Defence Policy and relevant national frameworks; highlight the main challenges and strategic directions in a changing security environment, absent the implementation of a National Defence Strategy.

Considered Sub research Questions

Sub Research Question 1: Does Irish defence policy produce coherence in threat diagnosis without producing coherence in strategic direction?

Sub Research Question 2: In the absence of a unifying strategy, how is strategic risk distributed across Ireland's defence architecture, and what institutional or operational vulnerabilities does this create?

Sub Research Question 3: Does this pattern of displaced risk materially weaken Ireland's credibility and increase its attractiveness as a grey-zone target?

Overview of Irish Defence Policy: Key Challenges and Strategic Directions



An examination of Irish Defence Policy and relevant national frameworks; highlight the main challenges and strategic directions in a changing security environment, **absent the implementation of a National Defence Strategy**

Adam Beatty
Wednesday 28 January 2026

Introduction 0 min 0 sec

Introduction and Executive Summary

- Dublin Airport drones exposed a strategic failure: Ireland lacked clear authority and ROE for decisive action
- Threat awareness exists, strategic choice does not: without strategy, risk is pushed downward rather than resolved
- Hypothesis: absent defence and military strategy to link means to political ends, Ireland is an open flank in politically salient moments

When drones appeared over Dublin, Ireland lacked a clear authority or ROE for interdiction

That incident wasn't a tactical failure – it was a strategic one.

It revealed a fundamental lacuna in how Ireland converts threat assessment into tactical action.

Ireland is not blind to the threats we face. We're simply not set up to make hard choices in response.

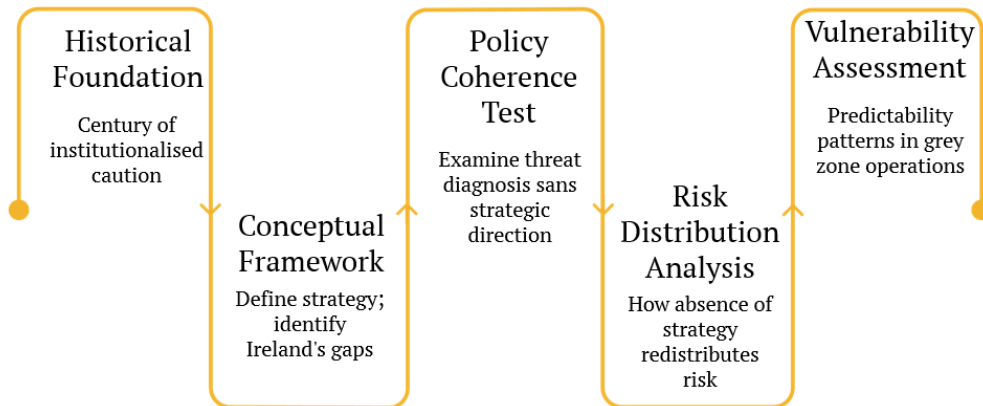
When strategy is absent, risk doesn't vanish;

instead it is pushed to the lowest level willing to carry it.

This presentation shall argue that: Absent both defence and military strategies to bridge military means to political ends, Ireland is an open flank during politically salient moments.

Slide 0 min 45 sec

Presentation Structure



To make that case, I'll do five things.

First, trace the history — how a century of institutionalised caution built the governance architecture we have today.

Second, define what strategy actually is — and show what that means for Ireland

Then I'll test three propositions:

Can Ireland produce correct threat assessment without coherent direction?

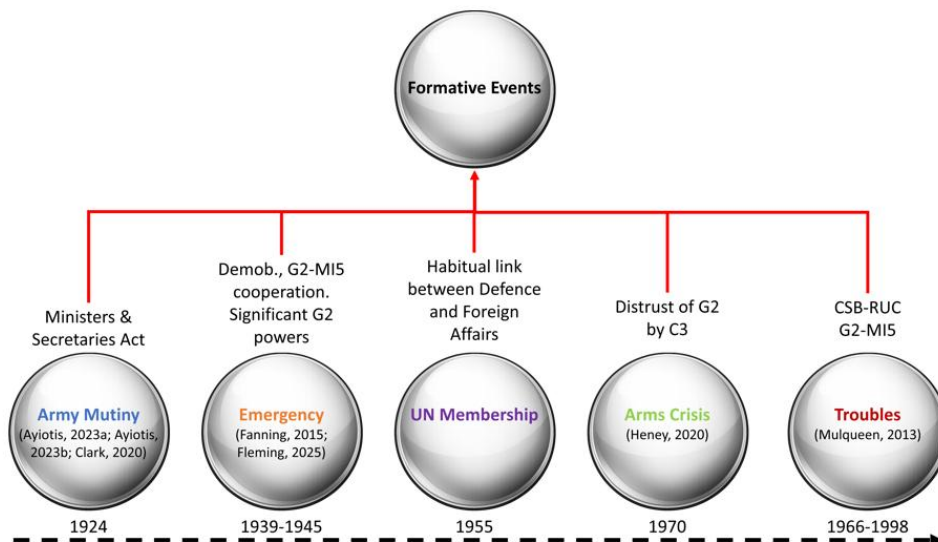
Absent strategy, how does risk redistribute across the system?

Is Ireland predictable — and therefore vulnerable — in the grey zone

Scene Setting

Slide 1min 20 sec

Historical Context of Defence in Ireland



Historical context is important. This diagram sets out formative events and sources underpinning my argument.

The Army Mutiny occurred shortly after independence.

Fearing a Coup d'état, Prime Minister Cosgrove had Justice Minister O'Higgins become the de facto head of government.

Through the subsequent 1924 Ministers and Secretaries Act, the military was clearly subordinated to the Minister,

embedding a strict civil-military separation broadly consistent with Huntington's logic of civilian control –

though implemented through administrative dominance rather than professional autonomy.

Civilian authority was operationalised through the Carltona Principle, whereby the officials may legally exercise powers in the Minister's name.

The effect was a durable governance architecture, designed to manage political risk.

Ireland's wartime neutrality has been mythologised as a moral stand.

However, the sources suggest it was rooted primarily in fear and material weakness.

Early neutrality was performative and realist in nature, reflected in support to the United Kingdom.

Fleming argues that post-war policy amounted to hedging: balancing formal neutrality with selective international engagement.

UN membership in 1955 proved pivotal.

It started an habitual association between the DF and the Department of foreign affairs.

This reinforced their role as an external-facing, legitimacy-conferring instrument of foreign policy rather than a domestically oriented deterrent.

During the Troubles, the DF were explicitly involved in internal security through ATCP.

However, intelligence authority followed a different trajectory.

G2's prominence during The Emergency gave way to enduring distrust following the Arms Crisis.

It consolidated political sensitivity regarding the military,

reinforcing a preference for oversight, fragmentation and restraint.

In essence, Óglaigh na hÉireann has transitioned from the primary instrument of independence,

to an institution feared as a potential threat to democratic authority,

and finally to its current role.

It is a value-adding enabler of foreign policy abroad, carefully constrained at home.

This condition is compounded by what Mearsheimer in 1990 describes as a broader Western tendency to treat the post-1945 long peace as normal rather than contingent –

Where Ireland interprets security issues normatively rather than strategically.

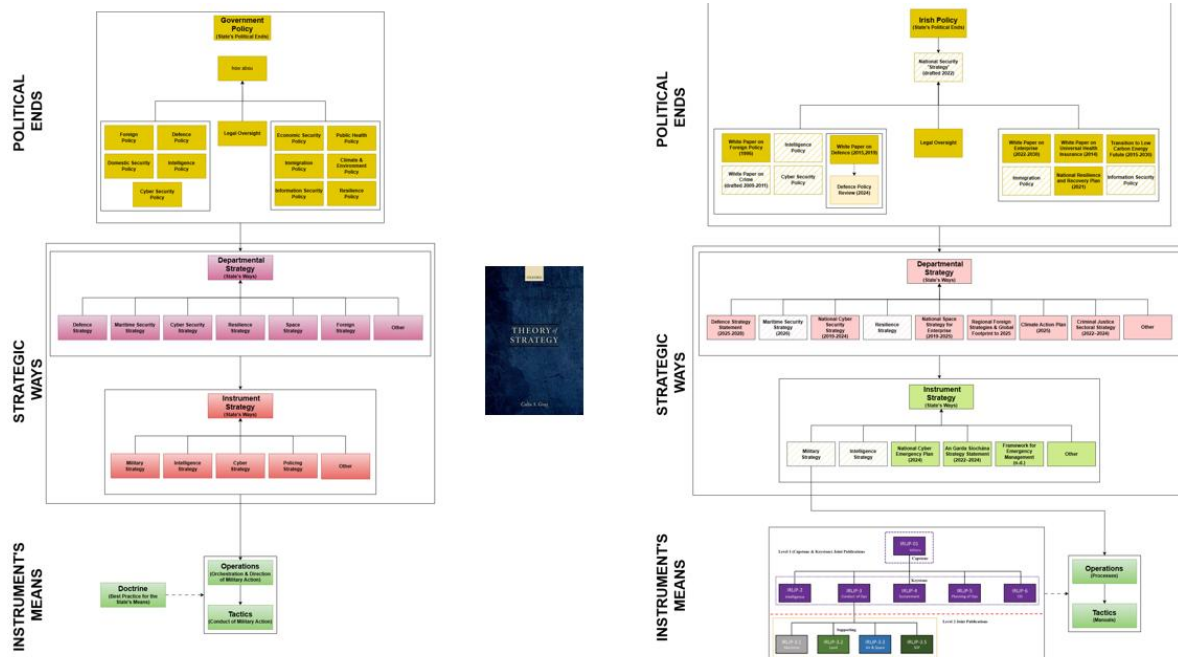
The strategic incoherence I describe today is therefore not accidental

It is the direct descendant of a century-long history of institutionalised **distrust, administrative control and culturally mediated risk aversion.**

That history matters because it shaped our default instincts.

Now I'm going to map the strategic architecture those instincts produced

Slide 4 min 13 sec



This slide is not intended to be read in detail; it's a map to orient the discussion and is printed for later review.

On the left, I reconcile Gray's 2018 grand theory of strategy with contemporary government structures.

Policy sets political ends: what the state seeks.

Strategy is the bridge connecting those ends to action through state instruments.

Tactics are the conduct of action.

operations orchestrate that conduct;

while doctrine codifies best practice.

All political ends are served by strategic ways – although only some employ military means.

Internationally, governments publish National Security Strategies as their highest-level policy statement, which I shall refer to as national security policy.

Click

Ireland does not publish such a document.

Political ends are instead articulated across fragmented policy documents.

Ireland currently lacks national security policy, a defence strategy and a military strategy.

Everything between political ends and the instruments of state is strategy — and that space is where Ireland is thin.

That's the context and the architecture. Now I shall turn to the problem it creates:

clarity on threats, but no strategy that forces prioritisation.

Slide 5 min 31 sec

Ireland's Security Policy Paradox: Diagnosis Without Direction

Consistency in Threat Assessment

Existing policy (CODF, Consult. Forum, DPR) and the emerging Maritime Security Strategy align on the contemporary security environment

Asymmetry in Policy Architecture

Politically coherent diagnosis of threats versus strategically incoherent translation into actionable direction and capability

Why This Gap Exists

- Political caution and institutional fragmentation
- Cultural assumptions about defence purpose
- Absence of orchestrating national security policy

Threat Analysis Alignment

Ireland's assessment mirrors partner and similar nations (Aus, NZ, Swe, UK)
Shaped by Russo-Ukrainian War, great-power competition & European instability

Ireland almost-uniquely lacks a national security policy. SDR (2024) largely functions as partial proxy. No coherent strategy exists to orchestrate force generation, capability development or strategic posture

CODF (2022), Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2024), Government Offices of Sweden, (2024), HM Government (2025), New Zealand Security Intelligence Service (2025), Richardson (2023), Senior officials under Chatham House rules (2025)

Across the Commission, the Consultative Forum and DPR and the emerging Maritime Security Strategy there is remarkable consistency in how the contemporary security environment is understood.

Irish defence policy today exhibits a fundamental asymmetry:

it is politically coherent in how it diagnoses threats, but strategically incoherent in how it translates diagnosis into direction.

This gap is not accidental.

It reflects deeper tensions between **political caution, institutional fragmentation and cultural assumptions about what defence is for.**

Strikingly, Ireland's threat analysis is consistent with partner and comparable nations' analyses,

such as UK, NZ and Sweden,

particularly in its reference to Russian actions

It has been shaped by the Russo-Ukrainian War, renewed great-power competition and wider European instability.

Here's the structural gap.

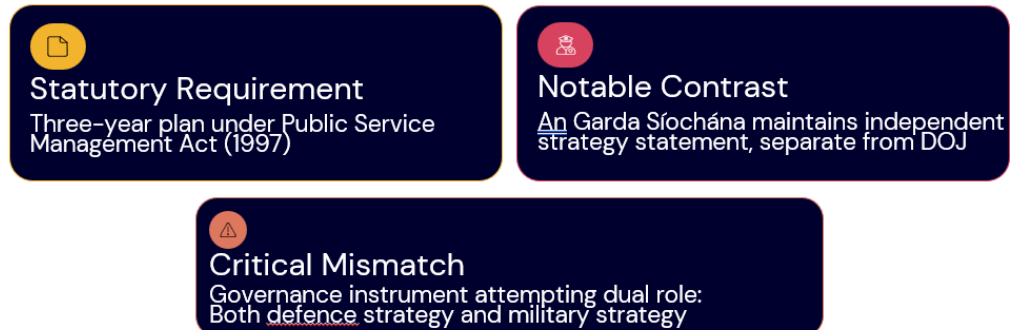
Ireland, almost uniquely, does not publish a national security policy,

with the Strategic Defence Review functioning as a proxy in some respects.

Ireland is absent strategy to orchestrate matters such as force generation, capability development and posture.

Slide 6 min 38 sec

Strategic Intent and Implementation Gaps



A governance compliance document is being tasked to fulfil the strategic functions of both comprehensive defence policy and operational military strategy – purposes for which it is not designed

An Garda Síochána (2022), Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2024), Government of Ireland (1997)

Hence, strategic intent defaults to the joint Department of Defence and Defence Forces Strategy Statement (2025).

This a three-year plan required under the Public Service Management Act 1997.

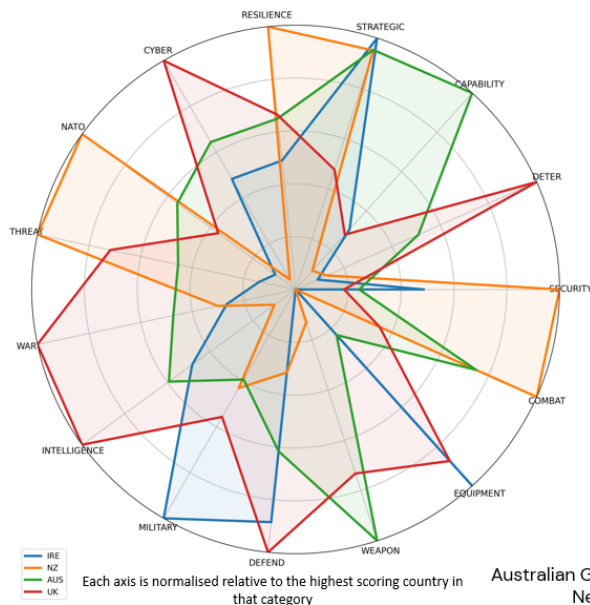
Interestingly, the Gardai have a strategy statement, independent of the DOJ.

Nevertheless, artefact mismatch follows:

a largely governance instrument is asked to do the work of both defence and military strategies.

Slide 7 min 05 sec

Comparative Language Emphasis in Defence Strategy Documents



Strategic Tone Comparison

- Ireland: markedly lower emphasis on force-planning vocabulary (war, weapons, combat, deterrence)
- Partners: deterrence-led profiles
- Ireland's flatter profile reflects a more corporate/managerial register
- Implication: Not just Ireland's strategic culture. **Threats described but avoids the language of response**

This slide depicted the results of a comparative keyword analysis of functionally equivalent defence strategy documents from Ireland, the UK, Australia, and New Zealand.

The analysis examines relative emphasis on coercive, military, and security-related terms, to indicate linguistic tone rather than capability or intent.

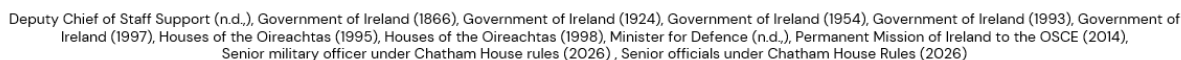
Ireland's profile is markedly flatter and contrasts with the deterrence-led profiles of other nations

While strategic culture and neutrality explain part of this difference,

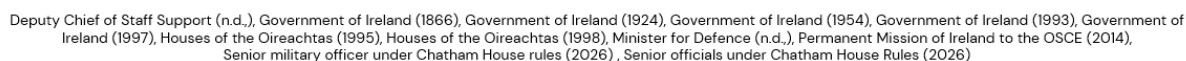
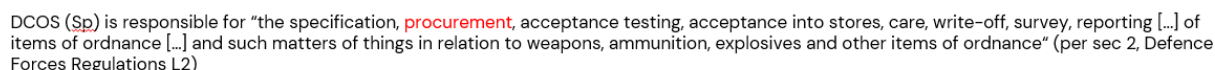
the absence of a national security policy or defence strategy leaves Ireland without a distinct register for defence

Ireland compresses the strategic discourse into a single, managerial document, which attempts – imperfectly – to bridge that gap.

DOD Structure and Delegation of Responsibility for Ordnance



DOD Structure and Delegation of Responsibility for Ordnance



For those interested, I have collated extracts from the legislation which I now discuss and can provide it on request.

The Minister is the head of the Department of Defence.

The Secretary General is the principal officer of the civil side of the Department and is appointed by the Minister for Finance as Accounting Officer for all defence expenditure

– elucidated in the 1866, 1993 and 1997 Acts.

In Defence Forces Regulation L2, – which is secondary legislation – DCOS (Sp) is assigned all responsibility for the materiel of warfighting.

However, an asymmetry of authority and structural misalignment exists,

In that the Secretary General controls subhead A8

from which ordnance is procured

effectively compelling DCOS, through admin instruction L2, to concede the administration of such procurement to the Sec Gen

which is a function given to him by the Minister.

This leads to a certain degree of tension between the civil and military sides of the department

The potential consequences of this tension are the absence of strategic prioritisation for the procurement ordnance equipment.

This affects the Equipment Development Plan.

What is missing is not awareness of this tension, but any defence strategy that directs its resolution.

Finance becomes the organising principle not because it is optimal for defence, but because strategy has not specified an alternative

Slide 9 min 25 sec

Policy Without Strategy: Direction by Inference

Without unifying strategy

Institutions infer direction rather than receive authoritative guidance

- Disrupts unity of effort
- Produces institutional tension
- Cannot compel cross-government alignment

Policy documents fall short

Articulates objectives and recognise threats – but cannot achieve tactical effect

- No authority to settle resource disputes
- Not mechanism for risk acceptance or temporal sequencing



The Independent Oversight Group exists precisely because strategy is missing.
It functions largely as an adjudication mechanism between defence requirements and fiscal constraints

Senior officials under Chatham House Rules (2026)

Without a unifying national security policy, defence strategy and military strategy which bridge ends, ways, and means,

direction must be inferred by institutions rather than enforced by political authority.

Policy allows ambition to accumulate.

strategy is what forces trade-offs.

Ireland has the former without the latter.

This can disrupt unity of effort and produce tension.

Without strategy, policy documents can articulate objectives and recognise threats, but they cannot achieve decisive tactical effect.

The Department of Defence and Defence Forces can describe what needs doing, but they cannot compel alignment across government,

nor can they authoritatively settle disputes over resource allocation, risk acceptance, or temporal sequencing.

The Independent Oversight Group, chaired by the Secretary General to the Government, exists precisely because strategy is missing.

It functions largely as an adjudication mechanism between defence requirements and DPER-imposed fiscal constraints

Slide 10 min 30 sec

Temporal Fragility in a Compressed Threat Environment

Assumption

Stability of rules-based order: facilitating incremental reform

Threat

The grey zone can compress warning time and punish delay

Verdict

Irish defence policy broadly understands the problem but lacks the strategy to resolve it

Coherence

Coherence in analysis but not in direction and action



Without a unifying National Security Policy and National Defence Strategy to impose hierarchy and compel alignment across government, coherent defence remains aspirational

Dixon (2025)

Finally, this condition is temporally fragile:

Ireland's approach assumes a permissive environment in which reform can be incremental,

yet hybrid pressure compresses warning time and punishes delay, per Dixon 2025.

Irish defence policy broadly understands the problem ,but lacks the strategy to resolve it.

Coherence exists at the level of analysis, not decision.

Without something to impose hierarchy and compel alignment across government, a coherent defence remains aspirational.

The next question is:

when strategy is missing, where does the risk go — and who ends up carrying it

CHALLENGES

Research Question 2

Research Question 2: Risk Displacement and Institutional Vulnerability

Slide 11 min 10 sec

Risk Displacement and Institutional Vulnerability

Absent defence strategy, strategic risk converts into practical shortfall: equipment gaps, capability deficits, operational constraints



Political Ends Articulated

Through policy documents

But no authoritative instrument translates them into prioritised ways for military means



Strategic Void

Consequential decisions about risk, sequencing, trade-offs settled implicitly through fiscal gatekeeping rather than by elected authority



Defence Forces Carry Risk

Strategic ambiguity becomes tactical burden – such as reported ammunition shortfalls

The absence of a National Defence Strategy constitutes a democratic weakness

Department of the Taoiseach (2025), Gallagher (2022), Gallagher (2025a), Gallagher (2025b), Gill and Phytian (2018), HM Government (2025)

Absent defence strategy, strategic risk is converted into practical shortfalls:

equipment gaps, capability deficits and operational constraints,

which are borne by the Defence Forces.

Ammunition is a useful vignette:

in my recent staff experience, availability was a persistent constraint.

I have since seen credible indications of further deterioration, sufficient to justify treating ammunition as a binding readiness risk.

Consider the intelligence domain as illustrative – which mirrors many of the same challenges as defence.

Intelligence arguably suffers from deeper ambiguities and vulnerabilities than defence – since no intelligence policy exists.

This cascades through the absence of a national intelligence strategy

Instead, it is Agency heads which must self-prioritise threats, per Mulqueen, Heney and Walsh.

As diagnosed in a previous presentation, this is a democratic weakness from the perspective of civil liberties.

I contend that the absence of a National Defence Strategy also constitutes a democratic weakness

because,

while political ends are articulated through policy,

there is no authoritative instrument to translate those ends into prioritised ways for the use of military means.

This leaves consequential decisions about risk, sequencing and trade-offs

To be settled implicitly through fiscal and administrative gatekeeping,

rather than explicitly by elected authority.

Risk migrates and remains invisible until tested

Slide 12 min 15 sec

Strategic Risk Displaced onto Defence Forces

1 Funding Shortfall

Government underfunded CODF
LOA 2 transformation request

2 Proxy Strategist

DPER prioritises housing, health,
education over defence – finance
making risk judgements whilst
Defence Forces hold tactical risk

3 Undefined Success

Government hasn't
defined what achieving DF
roles means – military
tacitly accepts risk
through strategic silence

Internal View

Budgetary control becomes strategy by
default through structural necessity

External Perception

Ireland presents as an open flank to
actors assessing grey zone opportunities



Without national security policy, fiscal constraints substitute for strategic direction – reinforcing vulnerability in an evolving threat landscape

Commission on the Defence Forces (2022), Department of Public Expenditure and Reform (2022), Lenihan (p. 15, 2025),
McDermott (2024), Senior officials under Chatham House Rules (2026), Wall (2025)

Government accepted the CODF LOA 2 transformation but funded half of the €3.4 billion requested, per Wall in 2025.

By contrast, McDermott and Lenihan report that €2.1 billion was spent on IPAS accommodation in 2023 — illustrating the State's capacity to mobilise when strategic priority is clear

Hence, key military capabilities remain unfunded.

In the absence of a national security policy, it appears that DPER functions as a proxy strategist,

prioritising housing, health and education over defence

in a manner out of step with EU partners.

Which is consistent with senior officials' comments under chatham house rules.

Should that be true, finance is making judgements about strategic risk while the Defence Forces hold the tactical risk

Furthermore, government hasn't defined what it means to achieve the roles of the DF.

Since the military has never articulated the strategy to achieve government policy, perhaps it tacitly accepts the risk for lack of capability.

Budgetary control thus becomes strategy by default,

not through overreach but through structural necessity,

constraining the Department of Defence's true agency.

This appears to be confirmed by the divergence between the CODF's scathing assessment of Defence Forces capability and DPER's largely positive OCR of the Department.

These findings are not contradictory — they measure different things.

Procedural success can coexist with strategic failure

This, in turn, makes capability gaps appear as a bureaucratic choice, arguably reinforcing Ireland's position as an open flank.

We've looked at the internal effect:

capability gaps, seams, and fiscal substitution.

Now I want to take the external view —

what that pattern looks like to an actor deciding whether Ireland is worth probing in the grey zone

Research Question 3

Research Question 3: Credibility Erosion and Grey-Zone Vulnerability

Slide 14 min 23 sec

Ireland's Grey Zone Vulnerability

When Displaced Risk Undermines Deterrence

Ireland's security posture exhibits a dangerous credibility gap

Displacing military risk without corresponding capability
investment: inadvertently signals exploitability

The paradox: awareness without action creates predictable vulnerability



Adversary Perception

Ireland seen as soft spot
between major power

Without clear protective
commitments

Strategic Calculation

Expect: Quiet management Vs
public confrontation

Reduces reputational cost of
grey-zone operations

Escalation Ambiguity

Adversaries infer limited
contestation of probing
actions

Irish defence policy acknowledges hybrid threats but lacks the strategic architecture to translate recognition into credible deterrence. Political responses remain predictably constrained – a calculus adversaries exploit

Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2024), Houses of the Oireachtas (2025a), Houses of the Oireachtas (2025b)

Displaced risk erodes credibility.

Reduced credibility lowers the cost of grey zone probing,

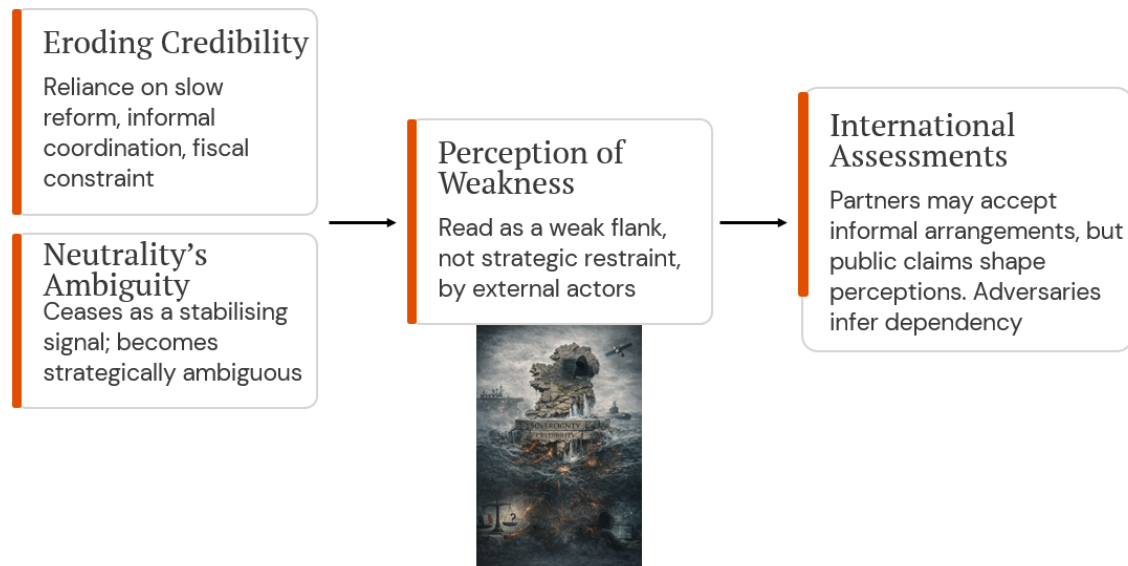
It increases Ireland's attractiveness as a grey-zone or hybrid target, per Hoffman 2007, particularly where attribution can be delayed, escalation can be controlled and political responses are predictably constrained.

The state signals awareness of grey zone threats in the Oireachtas and in policy

However, Ireland risks a credibility gap precisely because it has no strategic bridge

Slide 14 mins 35 sec

Ireland's Defence Credibility Gap



Dunphy (2025), Fitzgerald (2025), Gallagher (2023a), Gallagher (2023b),

Government of Ireland (1937), Houses of the Oireachtas (2025g), Meenan (2025), The Sunday Times Ireland (2025b), Webber and Warrell (2025)

In practice, credibility is eroded by slow reform, informal coordination and fiscal constraint.

From the outside, this reads less as strategic restraint and more as a weak flank

Partners may accept informal arrangements as a pragmatic response to Article 29.4.9 of the Constitution (1937).

For example, in a case currently before the courts, Senator Craughwell has alleged a “secret deal with the RAF” for airspace interdiction

Whether substantiated or not is secondary.

It is enough to shape perception.

Adversaries infer dependency.

Neutrality, in this context, ceases to function as a stabilising signal and instead becomes strategically ambiguous.

Slide 15 min 33 sec

Grey-Zone Coercion Thrives on Uncertainty

1 Undermine Public Trust

Exploiting inconsistencies to sow doubt

2 Foster Active Threat

Creating a sense of looming danger

3 Strategic Uncertainty

Blurring lines, making responses unpredictable

4 Weak Partnerships

Isolating and testing alliances within Europe



Case Study: Dublin Airport Drone Incident

Absence of decisive sovereign response: legal ambiguity, ROEs, limited counter-UAS, unclear escalation thresholds, inter-agency delay

Demonstration alone was sufficient for grey-zone actors

Ireland's neutrality is read as performative, creating opportunity for adversaries who see it as a soft spot with predictable, quiet responses to hybrid incidents

Gunnariussan (2019), The Irish Politics Newsletter (2025), The Sunday Times Ireland (2025a),

This ambiguity matters because grey zone coercion thrives on uncertainty.

Per Gunnariussan, Such actors probe to undermine public trust, foster a feeling of an 'active' threat, create strategic uncertainty to weaken partnerships within Europe

The issue is not that Ireland lacks intent to respond,

but that response options remain structurally constrained, undefined in strategy, and therefore predictable.

The Dublin drone incident illustrates this clearly.

Legal ambiguity over authority to act, ROEs, limited counter-UAS capability, unclear escalation thresholds and inter-agency delays

combined to produce public uncertainty.

Slide 16 min 15 s

The Gap Between Legal Authority and Operational Readiness

CO D6 Rules of Engagement: IHL-compatible, but culturally internalised (via ATCP/UN experience) as defence of 'self & post-protected'

Operational reality: Even if fire were ordered, no defence and military strategy existed to integrate capabilities into a coherent kill chain or manage whole-of-government consequences



The Debris Dilemma

No framework to weigh civilian/aviation hazard vs cost of inaction



Airspace Control Gap

No standing protocol to clear/control the engagement box



Broken Kill Chain

Discrete capabilities; no executable end-to-end targeting sequence

Missing defence and military strategy meant a kinetic "success" would still expose grey-zone response gaps

Chief of Staff (n.d.), ICRC (n.d.)

COD-6 ROEs are compatible with IHL and can be read as suitable for defence of the State.

In practice – shaped by ATCP and UN experience – they're often internalised as defence of 'self and post-protected'.

And even if fire had been ordered, there was no publicly articulated defence strategy for balancing the immediate hazard to aviation and civilians from falling debris against the political and military risk of inaction.

That matters: the binding constraint wouldn't just have been ROE,

But rather the absence of a pre-arranged plan to clear and control the engagement area.

We lacked the strategic layer to integrate separate military capabilities into a coherent kill chain

We also lacked the whole-of-government framework to manage the consequences of interdiction

The same pattern is visible in maritime domain awareness and subsea infrastructure protection, where awareness exists but escalation authority and prioritisation remain opaque.

Ireland's Neutrality: Strategic Vulnerability?

"Performative Neutrality":

Irish neutrality increasingly viewed as performative rather than principled

Creates exploitable ambiguity in grey zone operations consequences



Adversary Perception

Ireland seen as soft spot between major power

Without clear protective commitments

Strategic Calculation

Expect: Quiet management Vs public confrontation

Reduces reputational cost of grey-zone operations

Escalation Ambiguity

Adversaries infer limited contestation of probing actions

Grey zone probing alone may suffice – no actual incursion required to achieve strategic effect

Robinson (2025)

This matters from a grey zone perspective, where demonstration alone is sufficient.

As Robinson in 2025 noted, Irish neutrality is increasingly read as performative rather than principled.

From a Russian strategic perspective, this creates opportunity.

Ireland is seen as a soft spot between major powers.

Lacking clear escalation thresholds, adversaries infer that Ireland will manage hybrid incidents quietly rather than contesting them publicly,

This reduces the reputational cost of probing.

Proposition

Absent a defence strategy to bridge military means to political ends, Ireland is an open flank during politically salient moments

Falsifier

This proposition would be disproven if Ireland responded decisively to a hybrid attack using sovereign capabilities and clear escalation authority



I have argued that Ireland can see the threat picture,

but struggles to bridge the gap between policy and action

In the grey zone, that leaves Ireland as a vulnerable European partner

That proposition, is falsifiable.

It would fail if we could point to a case where sovereign capability was employed under clear authority,

agencies coordinated from a pre-arranged plan and consequences were managed in real time.

Dublin Airport is the obvious test case.

If it had demonstrated such coherence, it would have disproved my claim.

Instead, it exposed the gap.

Slide 18min 15 sec

Strategic Directions

Military Strategy

For assigned roles

Clear structures for grey zone
kill chains

Defence Strategy

Priority to capability
development

National defence industry

CHOD assigned as
accounting officer

Align Minister for Finance
direction with secondary
legislation

Restructuring Subhead A8

Maintenance of existing
equipment

Procurement of equipment for
new capability



Key test: does strategy shorten timelines for replacing existing equipment?
Currently 10 years to achieve **first deliveries** of replacement body armour

SSO Tech Services (2026)

This slide sketches the key strategic directions my research has elucidated.

Ultimately, the test of strategy is conversion:

I suggest that a key test be whether it enables the DF to deliver the replacement of existing material quickly and efficiently.

For example, It will have taken 10 years to achieve the first deliveries of a replacement body armour system, per my interview of SSO Tech services.

If these directions shorten materiel timelines, then they've worked.

Strategic Directions

Structured approach to national security: ownership, timelines, and deliverables across policy layers

Action	Owner	Timeframe	Key Deliverables	Focus Area
National Security Policy	Department of An Taoiseach	12 months	Whole-of-government grey zone playbook	Coordinated response to hybrid threats
Defence Strategy	Minister for Defence, ICCW Sec Gen & CHOD	18 months	Articulate strategy for defence and resilience missions	Strategic capability development
Military Strategy	CHOD / Joint Forces Commander	24 months	2-year replacement programme for existing equipment	Operational readiness and modernisation
Grey Zone Actions	Cross-departmental coordination	Immediate	Adaptive response mechanisms	Below-threshold threat mitigation

Layered approach ensures coherence from high-level policy through to tactical implementation, with clear accountability and phased delivery across 24 months

Government of Ireland (2022), Government of Ireland (p. 144, 2025), Walsh (2024)

This slide adds the sequencing and ownership

A National Security Policy has been signalled in successive Programmes for Government,

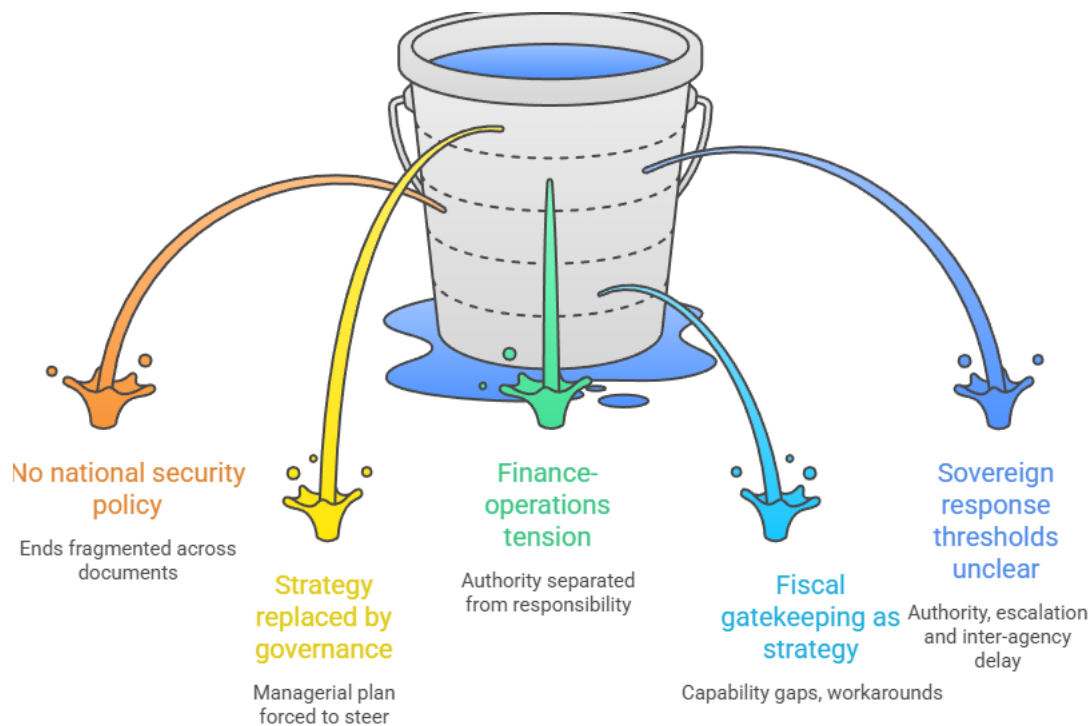
And was drafted NSAC since 2022, now requiring revision.

Much of the substance of a National Defence Strategy already exists across disparate artefacts, including the HLAP.

Based on reported current work on a defence plan and force design, the direction of travel appears toward a more explicit military strategy.

The key lacuna is to knit the instruments of the state together for effective grey-zone responses.

Slide 19min 25 sec



Ireland understands the problem.

The gap is in conversion:

Without strategy, risk isn't solved —

it migrates, into seams where no one owns the whole problem but everyone carries a piece of it.

And those seams are not hidden.

In the grey zone, they are precisely what gets exposed.

Dublin Airport made that visible.

Until a defence strategy bridges military means to political ends — and a military strategy translates that into an executable posture and kill chain — Ireland remains exposed during politically salient moments

20 min 20 sec

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